by connectivity and interconnected things. This ever-growing connectivity requires a powerful infrastructure that can address the needs presented by its users. Platforms at the core of this infrastructure are responsible for intricate management and connectivity of all connected devices.”

IoT platforms enable a secure connection between devices, and handle everything between networks, access points, hardware and applications. These are generally divided into three main types: application enablement/development platforms (AEPs/ADPs), data/network/subscriber management platforms and device management platforms (DMP).

AEPs provide foundational services that include application-making and enabling device management and communication, security, database, analytics and external interfaces.

Role of digital platforms to provide connectivity

The digital connectivity marketplace provides capabilities to exchange information and connectivity for new business models. Future digital connectivity marketplace will offer interaction between producers and consumers by exposing connectivity and cloud services on one side, and collecting requirements from consumers and matching them against capabilities of the services, on the other.

Services exposed in the marketplace could be supplied by multiple producers based on networks and infrastructures required to produce these services. Consumers representing various industries will require connectivity and cloud services to digitalise their business and operational processes.

Industries will require capabilities to express their requirements in languages and contexts that are specific to their business and operational environments. The

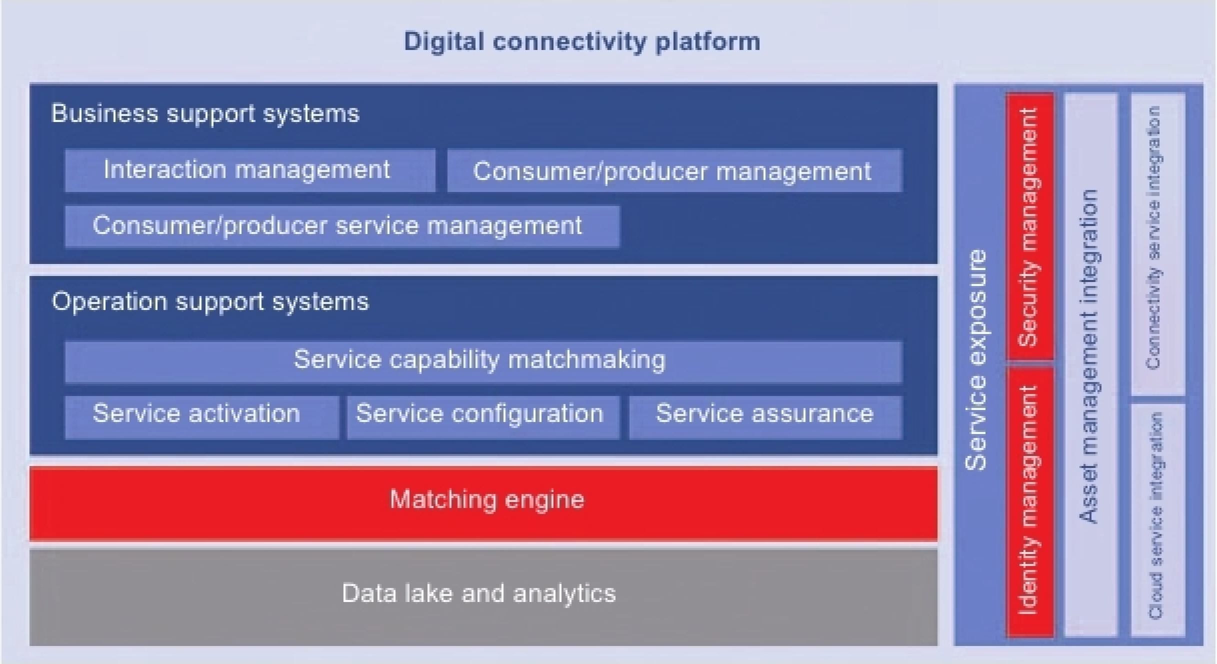

Figure 3: Digital connectivity platform (Credit: *www.ericsson.com*)

platforms will match industry-specific requirements with service capabilities enabling services for every ecosystem of consumers and suppliers.

The device connection platform (DCP) is a platform where mobile network connectivity services are exposed to be consumed by applications. Its fundamental purpose is to make connectivity available for enterprises to include in their offerings and provide the means to manage this connectivity, such as an automotive company and a camera manufacturer or automatic meter reading provider.

On one side of the platform are businesses and industries that are consuming services from the underlying infrastructure; on the other side are providers of network assets. DCP organises the relationships for optimal fit and usefulness for the players involved. In doing so, it provides several useful functions with one of the key values being scale of business and the networking effect that it has to offer.

Instead of competing for the same consumers with the same offer, operators that restructure according to a logic that enables full participation in an ecosystem platform will find themselves well-positioned to fully capitalise on new market opportunities.

Success path of digital platforms

The progressive nature of technological innovation exposes platforms to competitive pressure, forcing them to improve constantly. This competition exists on all sides of the market. For example, social networks like Facebook face competitive pressure from other social networks, which are also trying to attract and retain users, as well as from other online services, which are offering competing services for news and entertainment. And all of them are competing for advertising dollars.

Moreover, digital platforms are creating a more global labour market by keeping virtual teams connected and giving them the flexibility to set their schedule. Such platforms make it easier for companies to find customers, monetise under-utilised assets and ease transactions. These will also grow as they harness more data to better match users on different sides of a market, reducing transaction costs. END

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